

structure for nine months outside the league's duration. "The longevity, I mean, two to two-and-a-half months of the league and then, you know, not being present for nine months is something that needs to be solved, either by the league, the franchisees, or as a collective," Gupta says.

Paltan does that with its Yuva Paltan participating in age-group leagues. UP Yoddhas is exploring the academy approach that Paltan has patented. Telugu Titans, Mumba and Tamil Thalaivas have often supported local tournaments to blood talent, but are yet to either develop academy structures or get their main squad into competitive patterns outside the PKL.

Breaking the duopoly

Chandhok believes that a blanket expectation of more international tournaments does no good when the only two competitive teams are India and Iran.

"What are you going to gain from playing an eight-nation or a 10-nation tournament where you're just waiting for an India-Iran match? I can understand why you're not pushing hard to keep doing international tournaments when you might as well just do a bilateral series and be done with it."

It doesn't help that the Amateur Kabaddi Federation of India finds itself in all kinds of trouble. Despite a completed election and a declared winner, the court-appointed administrator continues to command the federation. This led to a blanket ban on Indian teams from tournaments like the first Senior Men's World Beach Kabaddi Championships in September, among a few others.

"I hope the handover happens so we're able to work with the federation and share our thoughts," Chandhok appeals.

He believes that cricket has lessons here too for kabaddi, and there is scope to develop an ecosystem that goes beyond pinning its hopes for solid competition at just the senior

nationals.

"Kabaddi does not have an equivalent of a Ranji Trophy or a Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy. There are no bilaterals. Cricket has so much outside the IPL. We have the Nationals and Junior Nationals that aren't televised robustly. All of this needs work. We need to have an open policy with distributing highlights so these tiers of the sport are seen. Exclusivity can come once the audience is captured as proper investors. Yuva Kabaddi has been building that, and we're getting there step by step. There's also the tangible contribution of supplying more than 90 scouted talents to the PKL. That's the big dog, the elite level. But the support is really needed at the bottom."

Regional focus

The league, after going through the 12-city rigmarole last season, has returned to a three-venue set-up this time with a two-fold motive. Not only does this drastically reduce operational costs,

but players also have to travel less and maintain steadier playing and recovery patterns. The league is also able to generate continuous kabaddi action without break days every week, which it hopes will reflect in broadcast numbers.

Hyderabad, Noida and Pune were the chosen venues this time, with two hotbeds of kabaddi, namely the Haryana-Punjab-UP belt and the Maharashtra belt, given priority. Other strongholds of the sport, like Tamil Nadu, missed out.

Gupta believes this is also the case for Bengal, but says that much more can be done than just wait for the league to be held there for three weeks. "Bengal used to be a very strong market for kabaddi in the 70s and 80s. Some of the best players

have come from there, but it has gone through its own turbulent times.

"The sport in the 90s and probably the early 2000s sort of dwindled. As a franchise, one of the top priorities on our vision board is to revive that culture here. COVID did not help, as it was a lost opportunity to engage



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